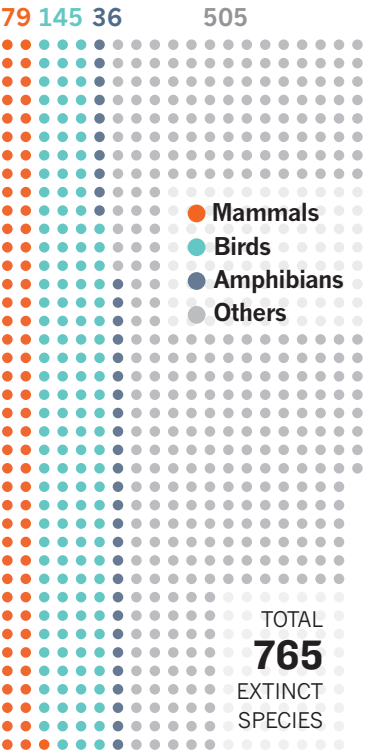


Life under threat

Thousands of species are currently deemed to be threatened, but the true number of species at risk of extinction may be much higher. Estimates suggest that between 500 and 36,000 species might be disappearing each year. The best data are for well-studied groups — mammals, birds and amphibians. Much less is known about threats to other groups, such as insects and fish.

ALREADY EXTINCT

TOTAL DOCUMENTED SINCE 1500



March towards mass extinction

Mass extinctions — loss of 75% of existing species — have happened 5 times in the planet's history. If there are 5 million animal species and they are disappearing at rate of 0.72% per year (the upper end of estimates), a sixth mass extinction could happen by the year 2200. At the low end of the estimated range, a mass extinction would not happen for thousands of years.

BY RICHARD MONASTERSKY | GRAPHIC BY 5W INFOGRAPHIC

Mammals

1,199

THREATENED SPECIES
26% of described species

Birds

1,373

THREATENED SPECIES
13% of described species

Amphibians

1,957

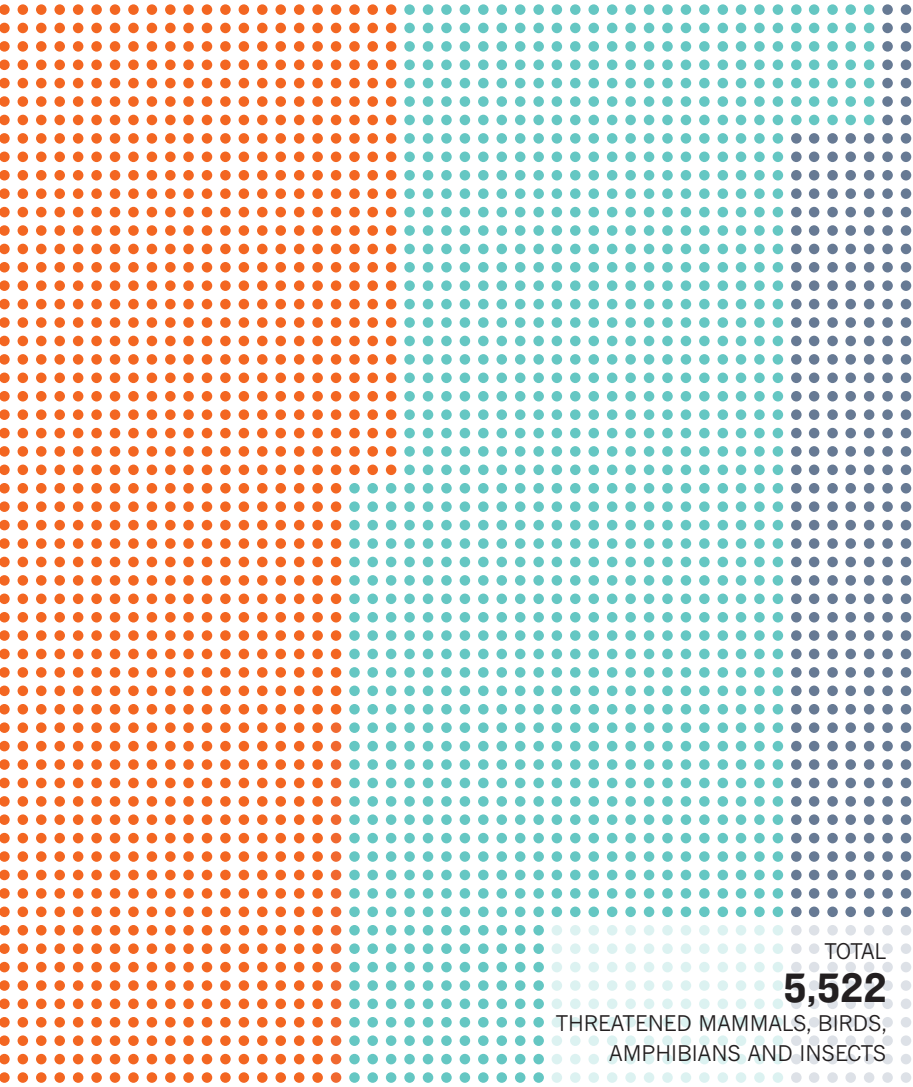
THREATENED SPECIES
41% of described species

Insects

993

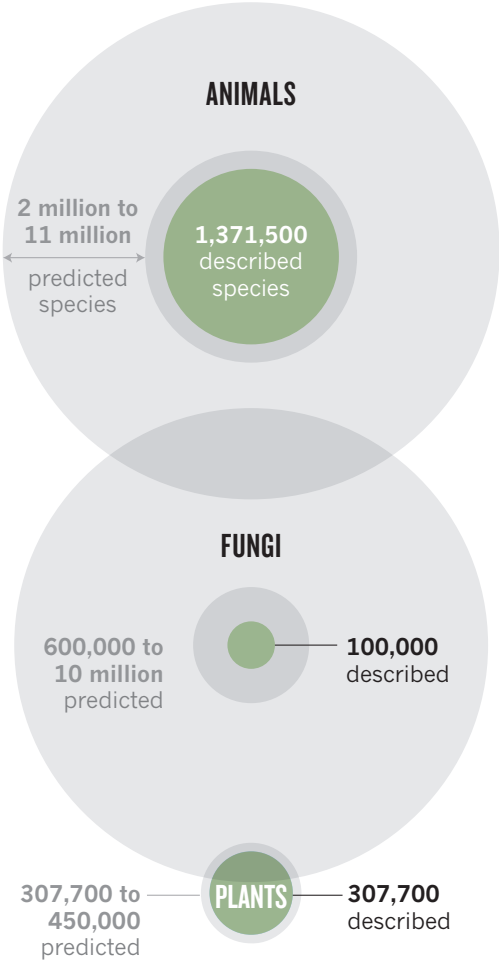
THREATENED SPECIES
(Only 0.5% of roughly 1 million described have been evaluated. Number of living species may exceed 5 million)

CURRENTLY THREATENED



How many species are there?

Estimates of the number of species of animals, fungi and plants vary significantly. That uncertainty clouds understanding of how many species are threatened and how many are going extinct.



Main threats

Hunting, fishing and other forms of exploitation are a major factor in declines in animal populations, according to the Living Planet Index. Habitat degradation and loss are also dominant threats. Climate change is expected to become a bigger factor over time.

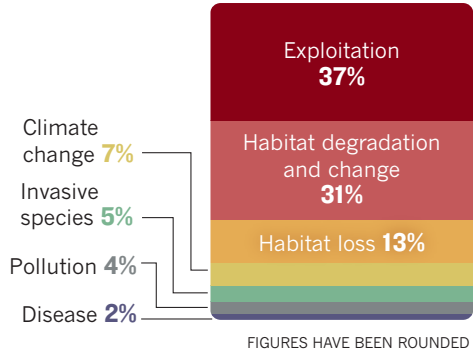


PHOTO CREDITS: *B. parvus* and *N. americanus*: Joel Sartore/National Geographic Creative; *S. demersus*: Life on white/Alamy; *R. summersi*: Joel Sartore/National Geographic Creative/Getty.

SOURCES: Already Extinct, Currently threatened: IUCN Red List. How many species are there?: S. L. Pimm *et al. Science* **344**, 1246752 (2014); B. R. Scheffers *et al. Trends Ecol. Evol.* **27**, 501–510 (2012); IUCN Red List. March towards mass extinction: Pimm *et al.*; C. Mora *et al. Science* **341**, 237 (2013). Main threats: *WWF Living Planet Report 2014*.